DEPARTMENT HEAD CAMPUS CONVERSATION

# Leading with faculty. Building on momentum.

Leadership philosophy, departmental vision, and academic record

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The Citadel · October 16, 2026

WHY THIS WORK · WHY HERE

# I know the work.
# I believe in the purpose.

## THE WORK I DO NOW

Professor of Finance and Chair of Accounting and Finance

- Director, Stephen & Gina Surace AI Trading Room
- Principal Investigator, Center for Business and Applied Ethics

**8**
full-time faculty

**7**
programs

**3**
tenure-track lines I helped secure

**$1M**
raised in gifts

## WHAT DRAWS ME HERE

As AI takes on more of the analysis, judgment and leadership become the scarce skills. The Baker School already builds both.

At a senior military college, the work of educating and developing principled leaders is daily practice, not a mission statement.

# Build structures that let others succeed.

The head's job is not to supply every answer. It is to create the conditions in which faculty and students can do their best work: shared decisions, visible information, protected time, candid feedback, and clear accountability.

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 1 OF 7

# Decisions are made *with* faculty.

Consultation must be able to change the outcome.

## UNDERWAY NOW AT SUNY POLY

### Undergraduate curriculum for CPA-120

**FACULTY DECIDE**

How the degree is redesigned for the 120-hour licensure pathway

**MY ROLE**

Frame the constraints, bring the evidence, carry the result forward

### A Master's in Accounting concentration

**FACULTY DECIDE**

Whether the concentration still earns its place

**MY ROLE**

Source alternative online courses so junior faculty can protect research time

*When a decision is made above the department, say so plainly.*

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 2 OF 7

# Make the arithmetic visible.

People can accept a difficult answer. An unexplained one corrodes trust.

SHOWN BEFORE THE DECISION, NOT DEFENDED AFTER

01

## The budget

What we actually have to allocate

02

## The numbers

What enrollment and demand actually say

03

## The constraints

Which are fixed, and which I will fight

> **Course assignments:** a new advisor teaching for the first time took every section of ACC 201, one preparation instead of several. Those sections came from tenure-line faculty. I explained the reasoning first, and they agreed.

**Since 2018** University-Wide Planning and Budget Committee

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 3 OF 7

# Grounded in data, not limited to it.

If only what we measure counts, everything we cannot measure becomes irrelevant by default.

IN PRACTICE

## Build the data we need.

I started collecting employment outcomes for our students. They showed a pipeline of finance graduates into Lockheed Martin in Syracuse, some in supply chain roles.

## Reason openly about the rest.

How CPA-120 will change graduate accounting enrollment: no data yet, and the decision cannot wait.

*What we cannot measure still counts.*

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 4 OF 7

# Faculty time is a fixed budget.

Adding tasks is easy. That is not management.

## HOW I MANAGE IT

### If I add a task, I take one away.

CPA-120 meant a stack of curriculum committee forms for the accounting faculty. In exchange, I got them off a university-wide service committee.

### Streamline what already exists.

Faculty reported publications, teaching, and service separately to the dean, the provost, AACSB, and Middle States. I cut that to one report.

*Management is making room for the work that matters.*

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 5 OF 7

# Tell people the truth early.

A colleague who first learns at the decision that the record was at risk was failed by everyone who saw it earlier.

**YEAR ONE**

## Explain the process

The written standards and where committee judgment enters

**YEARS TWO AND THREE**

## Give a candid midpoint read

Teaching and publication risks, not just totals

**BEFORE RENEWAL AND TENURE**

## No false assurances

Advocate without pretending to control the outcome

> Throughout: protect time  Shield pre-tenure faculty from service that crowds out the record

**No head can promise an outcome.** A head can make the risks visible early.

# Advocate for what faculty need.

Time and money for scholarship, argued for upward.

**WHAT I HAVE SECURED FOR FACULTY**

### Research funds

More support for the costs of doing research.

### Course releases

Teaching time returned to faculty with active research agendas.

### Aligned committee assignments

Committee assignments aligned with research activity and workload.

> **Nothing is free** More research funds came with higher research expectations. I say so up front.

# Own what happens next.

When results fall short, accountability means making sure evidence leads to action.

**68%**

met benchmark
Spring 2022

**DIAGNOSE**

Quantitative skill was the constraint

**ACT TOGETHER**

Brief practice across the curriculum

**80%**

met benchmark
2023–24

Same instrument. +12 points. Highest recorded result.

LEADERSHIP IN PRACTICE · FUNDRAISING

# Raise the resources. Then make them academic.

**$250K**

lead gift

**RECRUIT**

Matching donors

**$1M**

raised

**FUNDED**

AI Trading Room and the NYSTEC Business Center of Excellence

The harder work came after

5 courses · FinTech Club · 100+ students · 2 industry partners

**$200K SUNY grant** Center for Business and Applied Ethics, as Principal Investigator

# Growth comes from program design.

**+50%**

Finance enrollment
over five years

**Steady**

Accounting, through
CPA licensure shifts

**PROGRAMS I HAVE BUILT OR LED**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **2015** | Online MBA, Finance concentration | Clarion · built the curriculum |
| **2015** | M.S. Applied Data Analytics | Clarion · coordinated curriculum |
| **2019** | B.S. Finance | SUNY Poly · coordinator since 2020 |
| **2022** | M.S. Data Science and Analytics | SUNY Poly · committee member |
| **2025** | Ph.D. in Data Analytics | SUNY Poly · chair, under review |

One system, not three problems

curriculum · advising · recruiting · employers and alumni in the building

# Momentum is already visible.

Student-Managed Investment Fund

Rick and Mary Lee Bastin Financial Leadership Lab

Bastin Hall

Faculty work with generative AI

AACSB accreditation

**#1 Regional University in the South**

3 years running · Best Public University in the South for 16 years · U.S. News & World Report

HOW WE WOULD GET THERE

# Listen first. Earn the right to scale.

FIRST 90 DAYS

## Listen, map, return

- Faculty, students, staff, partners
- Map commitments and constraints
- Return what I heard, and where views differ

YEAR ONE

## Choose and pilot

- Faculty choose the questions
- Define evidence of success
- Run bounded pilots

YEAR TWO

## Scale or retire

- Scale what the evidence supports
- Resource faculty ownership
- Retire what did not, and say so

External engagement is the supporting layer

donors · advisory board · placements · capstones · regional partners

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 1

# A pipeline for changing CPA pathways

### CPA-120 AT SUNY POLY · SEPT. 2026

**0** new courses needed to meet New York's 120-hour pathway

ACC 312 Accounting Systems
now required, for accounting information systems

FIN 420 Financial Analytics
now required, for business data analytics

30 accounting credits (27 req.) · 23 upper-division (18 req.)

### QUESTIONS TO EXPLORE HERE

**LICENSURE**
How should changing pathways shape advising?

**EXPERIENCE**
How can internships help students begin the two-year pathway?

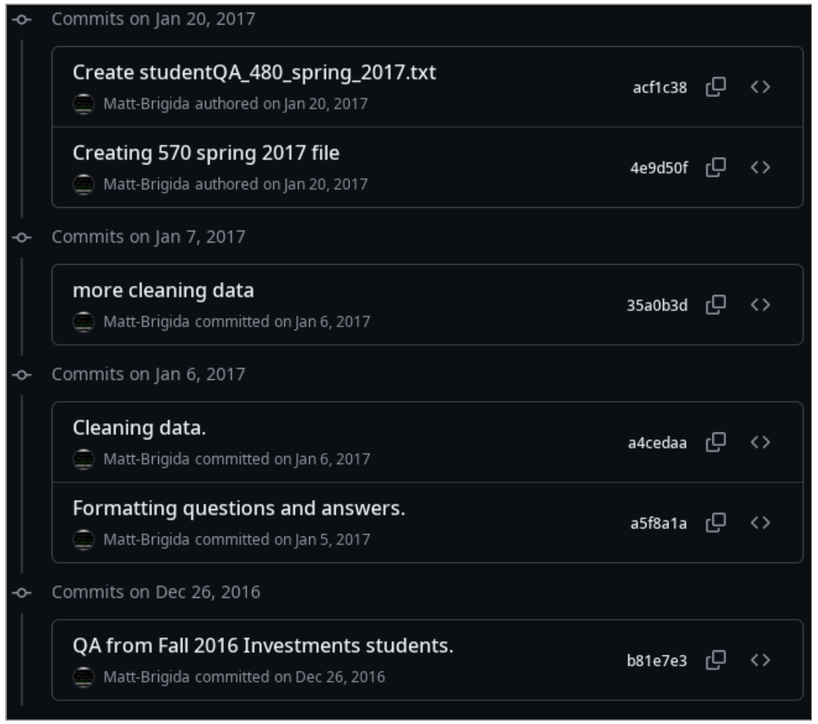
**CURRICULUM**
Where does analytics add real accounting value?

On accounting matters, I would lean on the accounting colleagues who own the expertise.

South Carolina, since June 30, 2025 Bachelor's + 2 years' experience, or master's or 150 hours + 1 year · exam window 18 to 36 months

BEFORE THE AI OPPORTUNITIES

# I have been building this for over a decade.




**First public commit: December 26, 2016** · my students' questions

**github.com/matt-brigida** Public code and data

FINANCE AI TEACHING ASSISTANT · SEQ2SEQ LSTM

Q What is a put option?

```
the right to sell a specific stock for a
specified period of time
```

Q What is the risk free rate?

```
The interest rate that can be earned with
certainty
```

Q What is Apple Inc ticker symbol?

```
It is known as their option.
```

Confident. Wrong.

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 2

# An AI-augmented investment fund

THE CITADEL'S PLATFORM

## SMIF + Financial Leadership Lab

EXPLORE TOGETHER

EXPERIENCE I BRING

## Director, AI Trading Room

5 courses · 100+ students · 2 partners

RESEARCH QUESTIONS THE LAB COULD TEST

**BEHAVIOR**

Does AI advice correct investor irrationality, or does the prompt induce it?

**STEERING**

Do models nudge investors toward particular products or strategies?

**DUTY**

Does an AI “fiduciary” make sense, and what would it owe?

*The aim is judgment with better tools, not judgment handed to tools.*

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 3

# AI in our DNA: transform in place

Make existing courses AI-native instead of bolting on new ones.

### ILLUSTRATION FROM THE PROPOSAL · FIVE EXISTING COURSES

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Add new AI courses | 10 COURSES | +1 FACULTY LINE | High COST |
| **Transform in place** | **5 COURSES** | **0 NEW FACULTY** | **Low COST** |

### EXAMPLE TRANSFORMATIONS

Introduction to Business
→ AI in Business

Management Information Systems
→ Cloud and AI Systems

Financial Markets and Institutions
→ Digital Finance: Markets and Institutions

**Why it matters** Every new course draws on the same qualified faculty, and AACSB sufficiency limits how far they can stretch.

## My proposal

Submitted to the SUNY Poly College of Business

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 4

# Defining teaching effectiveness together

The criteria should be developed with faculty before they affect faculty qualification.

+ Faculty-owned criteria aligned with mission
+ Multiple forms of evidence, not one metric
+ Expectations, feedback, and support in writing

AACSB 2026 · EFFECTIVE JULY 2026

## Standard 3.2

Teaching effectiveness becomes part of SA, PA, SP, and IP qualification.

40% SA | 90% SA+PA+SP+IP

Three-year ramp-up · evaluated from 2029–30

A PAUSE BEFORE THE RECORD

# Questions on leadership and vision?

## BUILD STRUCTURES THAT LET OTHERS SUCCEED

- Decisions are made with faculty
- Make the arithmetic visible
- Grounded in data, not limited to it
- Faculty time is a fixed budget
- Tell people the truth early
- Advocate for what faculty need
- Own what happens next

## IN PRACTICE

- $1M raised, then made academic
- Finance enrollment up 50% in five years

## OPPORTUNITIES TO EXPLORE

- A pipeline for changing CPA pathways
- An AI-augmented investment fund
- AI in our DNA: transform in place
- Defining teaching effectiveness together

TEACHING

# Remain close to the classroom.

Learn the concept, then test it on real market data right away.

**2**
courses each semester while chair

**4.3/5**
excellent teacher, 32 reports

**4.9 · 4.8**
two most recent sections

### 15 Python notebooks
Financial Analytics, with companion videos

### Interactive R/Shiny apps
Built for the Milken Institute's 5MinuteFinance

### Course databases
Tokenized stocks and perps, FDIC Call Reports, Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac loans

### Short video lectures
Alumni return to them before CFA and Series 63 exams

*Experiential, analytically serious, and attentive to what students can demonstrate.*

SCHOLARSHIP

# Keep inquiry active and connected.

**26 peer-reviewed articles** Publishing continuously through the chairship

CRYPTO

## Pricing and risk in cryptocurrency markets

Finance Research Letters 2026 · Economics Letters 2025 · Applied Finance Letters 2023

ENERGY

## Natural gas, oil, and electricity pricing and volatility

Energy Economics · Journal of Energy Markets · IAEE/USAEE Best Working Paper

BANKING

## Capital, risk, and bank safety

Managerial Finance 2025 · Applied Finance Letters 2022 · Banking and Finance Review 2019

SCHOLARSHIP · RESEARCH INFRASTRUCTURE

# Build the data the questions need.

CRYPTO

## Tokenized stocks and perpetual futures

Across multiple decentralized and centralized exchanges, for cross-venue research on stock-based crypto assets

ENERGY

## EIA data wrappers

Python and R access to the U.S. Energy Information Administration API; the R package is on CRAN

BANKING

## Every FDIC-insured institution

Financial data merged with FFIEC institution data

Why now — SEC Innovation Exemption, September 17, 2026: temporary, conditional relief for certain tokenized NMS stocks on permissioned venues

SCHOLARSHIP · IN PROGRESS

# Research that follows live questions.

### CRYPTO

The TVL Mirage: TVL Interactions, Ecosystem Activity, and Cryptocurrency Returns

### ENERGY

Natural Gas Pipeline Constraints, Market Integration, and Flaring

Diversification in Electricity Price and Volume Swaps (forthcoming)

### BANKING

Hedging Deposit Run Risk Prior to the 2023 Regional Banking Crisis

Cross-Sectional Variation in Uninsured Deposits (under review)

The Determinants of Uninsured Deposits

Regulatory Capital Levels and Noninterest Income

Account Fees at Minority-Owned Depository Institutions

*Seven working papers, one under review, plus one forthcoming article.*

INDUSTRY ENGAGEMENT

# Bring practice into the department.

**2025 TO 2026**

## Algorand Foundation

Chief Economist

Factor pricing models and cryptocurrency risk premia

**2022 TO 2023**

## Huntington Bank

Advisor, Treasury Analytics and Modeling

Term-structure forecasting and short-rate models for derivative valuation

**2014 TO 2021**

## Milken Institute

Financial Education Advisor

Applied research and interactive financial-education tools

**2009**

## NextEra Energy Resources

Business Management Analyst

Valuation of natural-gas-fired generation assets

**What it produces for the department**

course material · placements · capstone projects · advisory board members · donors

SERVICE

# The same philosophy, at university scale.

## Assessment and accreditation

Chair, College of Business Assurance of Learning (2024 to present) · AACSB Steering Committee (2018)

## University governance

Planning and Budget Committee (2018 to present) · College Leadership Committee (2020 to present) · Dean Search Committee (2018)

# Listen before setting direction.
# Make the reasoning visible.
# Build with the faculty.

Build on momentum. Explore deliberately. Own the outcome.

QUESTIONS AND CONVERSATION